

Means Of Grace

doc-means-of-grace

Soteriology · Means of Grace · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide
directness direct
variants not in scope

Statement under examination

God ordinarily nourishes faith and sanctifies His people through appointed means: the Word read and preached, prayer, the breaking of bread, baptism, and Spirit-empowered Christian fellowship.

In plain language

The verses here share one consistent pattern in the Greek. In Acts 2:42 a single ongoing verb, 'were continuing steadfastly' (proskarterountes), holds together four practices joined by repeated 'and' (kai): the apostles' teaching (didache), the fellowship (koinonia), the breaking (klasis) of the bread, and the prayers (proseuchais). The grammar treats these as a regular set of activities, not a one-time event. Romans 10:17 says faith ('pistis') comes 'out of hearing' (ek akoes), and the hearing 'through the word of Christ' (dia rhematos). The small words for 'out of' and 'through' name a source and a channel, so the spoken and read word is the appointed pipe through which faith arises and grows. In 1 Corinthians 11 Paul uses the standard verbs for handing on and receiving a tradition, 'I received' (parelabon) and 'I delivered' (paredoka), marking the supper as a fixed ordinance from the Lord. The command 'keep doing this' (poieite) is an ongoing instruction (present imperative) that carries repeated force, and the words 'as often as you drink' (hosakis), with 'until he comes', set the meal on a continuing timeline that 'proclaims' (katangellete) the Lord's death. Hebrews 10 tells believers to 'consider one another' (katanoomen allelous) so as to stir up love and not to abandon the 'assembling' (episynagoge), treating the assembly and mutual encouragement as a normal habit. First Timothy 4:13 commands devotion to the 'reading' (anagnosis), the exhortation, and the 'teaching' (didaskalia). Acts 2:38 commands 'be baptized' (baptistheto), a word ('baptize', baptizo) used 76 times across the whole Bible. So the bare claim, that God uses these appointed and repeated practices, is decisive and runs across the whole Bible. Where careful readers still divide is not whether these means exist but HOW they work. The key word is 'fellowship or participation' (koinonia) in 1 Corinthians 10:16, where the cup and the bread are each called a 'participation' (koinonia) of the blood and body of Christ. That word means sharing or communion, but the grammar leaves open whether the rite itself conveys that sharing or whether it is received by faith in the rite. The 'remembrance' word ('anamnesis') and the 'for forgiveness' phrase (eis aphesin) at baptism are open in the same way. The vocabulary settles that the means are appointed, but it does not rank the two ways of explaining their effect, and that single open point is the honest source of divergence.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0189	ἀκοή	akoe	hearing	24
G0240	ἀλλήλων	allelon	one another	100
G0320	ἀνάγνωσις	anagnosis	reading	3
G0364	ἀνάμνησις	anamnesis	remembrance	4
G0740	ἄρτος	artos	bread	

G0907	βαπτίζω	baptizo	to baptize	76
G1242	διαθήκη	diatheke	covenant	33
G1319	διδασκαλία	didaskalia	teaching	21
G1322	διδασχή	didache	teaching	30
G1459	ἐγκαταλείπω	egkataleipō	to leave behind	
G1997	ἐπισυναγωγή	episynagoge	gathering	2
G2605	καταγγέλλω	katangelo	to proclaim	18
G2657	κατανοέω	katanoeo	to observe	14
G2800	κλάσις	klasis	breaking	2
G2806	κλάω	klao	to break	14
G2842	κοινωνία	koinonia	participation	19
G2983	λαμβάνω	lambanō	to take	
G3740	ὅσάκις	hosakis	whenever	3
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidomi	to deliver	119
G3880	παραλαμβάνω	paralambano	to take	49
G4221	ποτήριον	potērion	cup	
G4335	προσευχή	proseuche	prayer	36
G4342	προσκαρτερέω	proskartereo	to continue in/with	10
G4487	ῥῆμα	rhema	declaration	67

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The cited verses converge on one stable, whole-Bible pattern (spread across the whole Bible): God ordinarily works through appointed, repeated practices. Acts 2:42 binds four 'to/with' nouns (datives, a noun in the 'to-X' or 'with-X' grammatical form) under one ongoing -ing verb form (durative participle), 'were continuing steadfastly' (proskarterountes, Strong's G4342), namely the apostles' teaching, fellowship (koinonia), the breaking of the bread, and the prayers (proseuchais, Strong's G4335). Romans 10:17 grounds faith ('pistis') in 'out of hearing' (ek akoes), and the hearing 'through the word of Christ' (dia rhematos Christou), naming source and instrument. First Corinthians 11:23-26 hands on a repeated rite using the technical handing-over verbs 'received' (paralambano) and 'delivered' (paradidomi), with present-tense 'keep doing' commands (present imperatives, ongoing instructions) 'poieite', and the indefinite-frequency adverb 'as often as' (hosakis, Strong's G3740). Hebrews 10:24-25 and 1 Timothy 4:13 add the gathered assembly (episynagoge, Strong's G1997), mutual stirring, and the reading, exhortation, and teaching of the word. The vocabulary about appointed means is decisive. What the words do NOT settle is the MODE of efficacy (how exactly the grace works): 'fellowship' or 'participation' (koinonia, Strong's G2842) in 1 Corinthians 10:16 means sharing or participation but does not by itself say whether grace is conferred by the rite or received by faith in the rite. The bare proposition stands; the contested mechanism is left open by the lexicon.

Scripture

Acts.2.42 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4342 προσκατερέω, G1322 διδασκία, G2842 κοινωνία, G2800 κλάσις, G4335 προσευχή

Force. One ongoing -ing verb form (durative participle), 'were continuing steadfastly' (proskarterountes, Strong's G4342), in the present active (an ongoing simple action), governs four 'to/with' nouns (datives, in the 'to-X' or 'with-X' grammatical form) joined by repeated 'and' (kai): the apostles' teaching (didache, Strong's G1322), the fellowship or sharing (koinonia, Strong's G2842), the breaking (klasis, Strong's G2800) of the bread, and the prayers (proseuchais, Strong's G4335). The grammar treats them as a coordinated, ongoing set of practices, not single events, which supports these as appointed, repeated means that sustained the early community. Note the word for the breaking here is the noun 'breaking' (klasis, Strong's G2800), not the verb 'break' (klao).

Rom.10.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0189 ἀκοή, G4487 ῥῆμα

Force. Faith ('pistis', Strong's G4102) is 'out of hearing' (ex akoes, Strong's G0189), with the preposition 'out of' (ek, Strong's G1537) marking source, and the hearing is 'through the spoken word of Christ' (dia rhematos Christou, Strong's G4487), with the preposition 'through' (dia, Strong's G1223) marking instrument. The proclaimed word is named as the appointed channel through which faith arises. The word for 'hearing' (akoe) occurs twice in this verse, first in the 'from' grammatical form (genitive) and then as a subject (nominative), and across its 24 occurrences in the whole Bible it carries two attested senses, the act of hearing and the thing heard or report, for example in Romans 10:16 and Galatians 3:2,5. Either sense keeps the word as the operative channel.

1Cor.10.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2842 κοινωνία, G2806 κλάω, G4221 ποτήριον

Force. The cup of blessing which 'we bless' (eulougoumen, Strong's G2127, present active, an ongoing simple action), and the bread which 'we break' (klomen, Strong's G2806, present active, an ongoing simple action), are each said to be a 'sharing or participation' (koinonia, Strong's G2842) of the blood and of the body of Christ. Here 'koinonia' governs an objective 'of-X' noun (objective genitive, a noun in the 'of-X' grammatical form acting as the object of the action), namely 'of the blood' (tou haimatos) and 'of the body of Christ' (tou somatos tou Christou). This 'of-X' form is the crux: 'koinonia' is genuinely two-sided in sense, a sharing IN something or a communion produced BY sharing, and the word alone does not say whether the rite conveys that participation or whether it is received by faith. This is where readings diverge.

1Cor.11.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3880 παραλαμβάνω, G3860 παραδίδωμι

Force. Paul uses 'I received' (parelabon, Strong's G3880) and 'I delivered' (paredoka, Strong's G3860), the technical verbs for handing on and receiving a tradition, marking the supper as a fixed ordinance received 'from the Lord' (apo tou Kyriou) and delivered to the church. The same root 'hand over' (paradidomi) also describes the Lord being handed over, 'was being delivered' (paredideto), in the same verse, in a completed past action or ongoing past action form (aorist or imperfect passive), but the transmission language frames the rite itself as appointed rather than improvised.

1Cor.11.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2806 κλάω, G0364 ἀνάμνησις

Force. 'He broke it' (eklasen, Strong's G2806), and the command 'keep doing this' (touto poieite, Strong's G4160), an ongoing instruction (present imperative), plus 'for my remembrance' (eis ten emen anamnesin, Strong's G0364), establishes a repeated commemorative act tied to the broken bread. The ongoing instruction (present imperative) carries repeated force, supporting an ongoing appointed practice. The word for 'remembrance' (anamnesis) is rare, with 4 occurrences total, in Luke 22:19, here, the next verse, and Hebrews 10:3, and it states the function of the act, remembrance, not the mechanism by which grace is communicated.

1Cor.11.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3740 ὡςάκις, G1242 διαθήκη, G4221 ποτήριον

Force. 'Do this, as often as you drink' (touto poieite, hosakis ean pinete, Strong's G3740), with the cup named 'the new covenant' (he kaine diatheke, Strong's G1242) in my blood, presents the rite as recurring and covenantal. The adverb 'as often as' (hosakis) is rare, with only 3 occurrences total, here, the next verse, and Revelation 11:6, and its indefinite-frequency clause (an 'as often as' clause that assumes repeated occasions) assumes a continuing observance rather than a single event.

1Cor.11.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3740 ὡςάκις, G2605 καταγγέλλω

Force. 'For as often as' (hosakis gar, Strong's G3740) you eat the bread and drink the cup, 'you proclaim' (katangellete, Strong's G2605, present active, an ongoing simple action), the Lord's death, 'until he comes' (achri hou elthe, Strong's G0891). The verb 'you proclaim' (katangellete) makes the meal itself a proclamation, and the 'until' clause sets it on a continuing timeline bounded by Christ's return. Both features support an appointed, ongoing practice.

Heb.10.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2657 κατανοέω, G0240 ἀλλήλων

Force. 'Let us consider one another' (katanoomen allelous, Strong's G2657 and G0240), a 'let us' command form (present subjunctive, an ongoing 'let us' instruction), 'toward a stirring up of love and good works' (eis paroxysmon agapes kai kalon ergon), makes mutual attentiveness a deliberate communal stimulus. The reciprocal pronoun 'one another' (allelous) shows the body acting on its own members, supporting Spirit-empowered fellowship as a means of growth.

Heb.10.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1997 ἐπισυναγωγή, G1459 ἐγκαταλείπω

Force. 'Not forsaking' (me egkataleipontes, Strong's G1459), an ongoing -ing form (present participle), 'the assembling of ourselves' (ten episynagogen heauton, Strong's G1997), together with the ongoing -ing form 'encouraging' (parakalountes, Strong's G3870), treats the gathered assembly as a normative ongoing habit. The noun for 'assembly' or 'gathering' (episynagoge) is rare, with only 2 occurrences, here and 2 Thessalonians 2:1. The prohibition against abandoning it implies the assembly is the setting where the other means operate.

1Tim.4.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0320 ἀνάγνωσις, G1319 διδασκαλία

Force. 'Attend to the reading, the exhortation, the teaching' (proseche te anagnosei, te paraklese, te didaskalia, Strong's G4337, G0320, G1319). Three 'to/with' nouns each marked 'the' (datives with the article, in the 'to-X' grammatical form, with 'the') name fixed public ministries of the word, and the ongoing instruction (present imperative) 'attend to' (proseche) commands sustained devotion to them. The word for 'reading' (anagnosis) is rare, with 3 occurrences, here, Acts 13:15, and 2 Corinthians 3:14, and denotes public reading of Scripture, supporting the Word read and preached as an appointed means.

Acts.2.38 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G2983 λαμβάνω

Force. 'Repent and let each be baptized' (metanoesate kai baptistheto hekastos, Strong's G0907), a completed-action passive command (aorist passive imperative, a completed-action instruction in passive voice), 'for the forgiveness of sins' (eis aphesin ton hamarton), and 'you will receive' (lempsesthe, Strong's G2983, future middle, a future action the subject takes part in) the gift of the Holy Spirit. The verb 'baptize' (baptizo) occurs 76 times across the whole Bible and is a commanded, appointed practice, which supplies the lexical basis for baptism named in the proposition. Whether the 'for' or 'into' clause (eis-clause, an 'into-X' phrase) marks instrument, occasion, or ground of forgiveness is the same kind of openness seen with 'fellowship' or 'participation' (koinonia): the syntax does not by itself fix the mode.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.2.42	Acts.20.7	tsk	1
Acts.2.42	Acts.1.14	tsk	1
Acts.2.42	Acts.2.46	tsk	1
Rom.10.17	Rom.10.14	tsk	1
Rom.10.17	Jer.23.28	tsk	1
1Cor.10.16	1Cor.10.20	tsk	1
1Cor.10.16	1Cor.11.23	tsk	1
1Cor.11.23	1Cor.15.3	tsk	1
1Cor.11.24	1Cor.5.7	tsk	1
1Cor.11.24	Exod.12.14	tsk	1
1Cor.11.25	Luke.22.20	tsk	1
Heb.10.24	Heb.13.3	tsk	1
Heb.10.25	Matt.18.20	tsk	1
1Tim.4.13	Deut.17.19	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.10.16 · addressed

'Sharing or participation' (koinonia, Strong's G2842) of the blood and body governs an objective 'of-X' form (objective genitive, a noun in the 'of-X' grammatical form acting as the object of the action) that the word itself does not disambiguate. 'Koinonia' means sharing, participation, or partnership, and it occurs 19 times from Acts 2:42 to 1 John 1:3 with that range stable, but it never specifies the metaphysics of HOW the sharing is effected. So the verse supports the supper as a means by which believers share in Christ, which the proposition affirms, while leaving open whether the rite conveys grace or whether grace is received by faith in the rite. The verdict rests on the appointed, participatory character the vocabulary does establish and does not overreach into the mode the vocabulary leaves open.

1Cor.11.24 · addressed

'For my remembrance' (eis ten emen anamnesin, Strong's G0364) locates the stated function of the rite in commemoration and proclamation. 'Remembrance' (anamnesis) is rare, with 4 occurrences, and names the purpose of the act rather than an automatic conferral mechanism. This neither requires nor excludes a grace-conveying sense, so it does not by itself decide the mode question. The appointed and repeated character carried by the ongoing instruction (present imperative) 'keep doing this' (poieite) and the frequency clauses still stands regardless of which mode a reader adopts.

Acts.2.38 · addressed

'Let him be baptized for the forgiveness of sins' (baptistheto eis aphesin ton hamarton) places an 'into-X' phrase (eis-clause) after the baptism command. The preposition 'into' or 'for' (eis, Strong's G1519) can mark goal, result, ground, or occasion, and the syntax does not select one. This is the same openness as 'fellowship' or 'participation' (koinonia): the verse establishes baptism as a commanded appointed practice, which the proposition affirms, but the preposition does not by itself fix whether baptism conveys forgiveness or accompanies a forgiveness received otherwise. The verdict affirms baptism as an appointed means without resolving the disputed mode.

Concordance traversed

G2842, G0189, G4487, G2806, G2800, G0364, G3740, G3860, G3880, G4342, G4335, G0907, G1997, G2657, G0240, G2605, G1322, G1319, G0320, G1242, G4221, G0740

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

No variant units were supplied in the bundle and all cited passages fall outside the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) published window, which covers only 3 John. The minor marked readings in the supplied text, for example 'was being delivered' (paredideto) in 1 Corinthians 11:23 and the cup clause wording, do not touch the lemmas (dictionary forms of words) that carry the verdict. The means-vocabulary, namely hearing (akoe), breaking (klao and klasis), fellowship or sharing (koinonia), remembrance (anamnesis), frequency (hosakis), assembly (episynagoge), baptism (baptizo), and the reading (anagnosis) and teaching (didache, didaskalia) terms, is textually stable, so the verdict does not depend on any disputed manuscript choice.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked

efficacious or conferring reading of the ordinances: consistent · On this reading 'fellowship or participation' (koinonia, Strong's G2842) in 1 Corinthians 10:16 is a real participation that the rite effects, an objective sharing in the blood and body, and the 'into-X' phrase (eis-clause) of Acts 2:38 ties baptism to the forgiveness it names. The handing-on verbs 'received' (paralambano) and 'delivered' (paradidomi), the covenant cup of 'the new covenant' (he kaine diatheke), and the ongoing instruction (present imperative) 'keep doing this' (poieite) present the supper as a divinely appointed channel through which grace is communicated. The lexicon permits this because 'koinonia' genuinely can denote participation IN a thing, and 'into' or 'for' (eis) can mark the ground or goal of the act.

instrumental or symbolic reading of the ordinances: consistent · On this reading 'remembrance' (anamnesis, Strong's G0364), 'for my remembrance', and 'you proclaim' (katangello, Strong's G2605, 'you proclaim the Lord's death'), frame the supper as a commemorative proclamation in which grace is received by faith looking to Christ, not conferred by the elements. 'Fellowship or participation' (koinonia) denotes the fellowship and shared belonging that faith enjoys, and the 'into-X' phrase (eis-clause) of Acts 2:38 marks goal or occasion rather than instrument. The lexicon permits this equally because 'koinonia' can denote communion produced BY sharing and 'into' or 'for' (eis) carries multiple senses. The means are appointed occasions where faith receives what the word promises.

The verdict on the bare proposition rests on grammatical features observable independent of any tradition: an ongoing -ing verb form (durative present participle), ongoing instructions (present imperatives), indefinite-frequency adverbs ('as often as'), reciprocal pronouns ('one another'), and prepositions marking source and instrument ('out of' and 'through'). Both lenses agree these are appointed, repeated means. They diverge only on the MODE of

efficacy (how exactly the grace works), and that divergence traces to an 'of-X' form (genitive) and a preposition the vocabulary does not rank, not to any external framework.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. God ordinarily nourishes faith and sanctifies His people through appointed and repeated practices: the reading and proclamation of His word, prayer, the breaking of bread, baptism, and mutual fellowship in the assembly.

The phrase 'means of grace' is a theological category term that can imply a specific conferral mechanism. The neutralized form replaces it with 'appointed and repeated practices' and keeps the question on whether the cited verbs, participles ('-ing' verb forms), and frequency clauses establish these as ongoing God-appointed channels. The verdict was derived on that neutralized sense and affirms the bare proposition. Two corrections to the prior file, neither VERDICT-CHANGED: in Acts 2:42 the breaking term queried in the whole Bible is the noun 'breaking' (klasis, Strong's G2800), not the verb 'break' (klao, Strong's G2806), and the assembling noun in Hebrews 10:25 is the noun 'assembly' (episynagoge, Strong's G1997), not the verb 'gather together' (episynago, Strong's G1996). Baptism, named in the proposition but absent from the supplied bundle, is now grounded directly: the verb 'baptize' (baptizo, Strong's G0907) occurs 76 times including Acts 2:38, so the baptism leg no longer rests only on the general pattern.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.10.16
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Acts.2.42
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.10.17
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.24
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.10.25
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2842
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0189
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0364
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3740
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.10.16
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License audit

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